

Cathartes aura

Turkey vulture

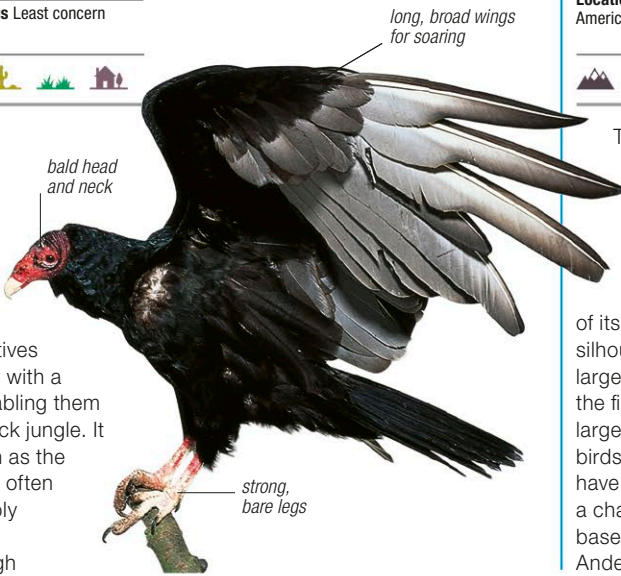


Length 25–32 in (64–81 cm)
Weight 1¼–4½ lb (0.85–2 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location S. Canada to S. South America



Often called a “buzzard” in the USA, the turkey vulture is found in an exceptionally wide range of habitats from southern Canada through to Tierra del Fuego. This vulture and its close relatives are the only birds of prey with a good sense of smell, enabling them to locate food even in thick jungle. It soars and glides as soon as the day has warmed up, and often feeds on road kill, possibly explaining its increase in populated areas. Although



little is known about its courtship behavior, this bird has been seen performing a ritualized dance on the ground. The female lays 2 eggs and both parents bring food to the young, which are fed by regurgitation from the parents’ crops. Once past their first year, the young birds are likely to live for 12–17 years.

Vultur gryphus

Andean condor



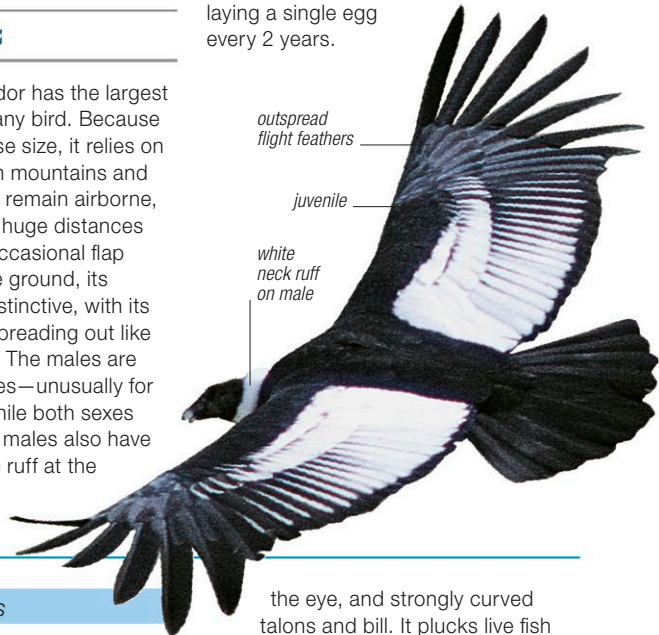
Length 3¼–4¼ ft (1–1.3 m)
Weight 24–33 lb (11–15 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened

Location W. South America



The Andean condor has the largest wing area of any bird. Because of its immense size, it relies on updrafts from mountains and coastal cliffs to remain airborne, and can travel huge distances with only the occasional flap of its wings. From the ground, its silhouette is highly distinctive, with its large flight feathers spreading out like the fingers of a hand. The males are larger than the females—unusually for birds of prey—and while both sexes have bald heads, the males also have a characteristic white ruff at the base of their necks. Andean condors

feed mainly on carrion, and soar at altitudes of up to 18,000 ft (5,500 m) to search for food. Their diet is wide-ranging, and includes not only mountain animals, but also the remains of stranded marine animals, such as seals and whales. In some places, they also feed at seabird colonies, plundering large numbers of eggs. They breed on inland cliffs and reproduce slowly, typically laying a single egg every 2 years.



Gymnogyps californianus

California condor



Length 4–4¼ ft (1.2–1.3 m)
Weight 18–31 lb (8–14 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Critically endangered

Location W. USA (California, Arizona)



The California condor is the largest flying bird in North America, and also one of the most endangered. Once found from California to Florida, by 1987 the species no longer existed in the wild, but a captive-breeding program (see panel, below) is slowly helping it recover. California condors are expert at soaring and spend much of their time circling high in the air. At one time, they fed mainly on the remains of bison and pronghorns, but with the arrival of Europeans, this

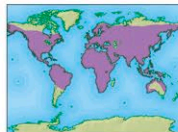


BLACK PLUMAGE
The California condor has mainly black plumage with white tips to the smaller wing feathers and a black neck ruff. The head and the upper part of the neck lack feathers.

abundant food source rapidly declined. Today, captive-bred condors that have been released feed mainly on dead cattle and deer.

Pandion haliaetus

Osprey



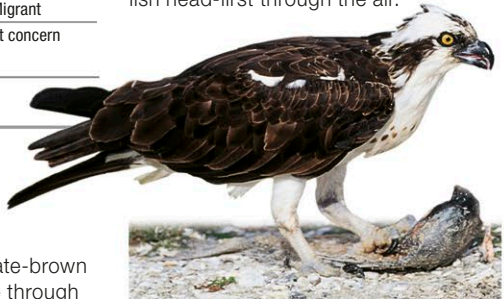
Length 21½–25 in (54–64 cm)
Weight 3¼–4½ lb (1.5–2 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Worldwide (except Antarctica)



One of the most widespread birds of prey, the osprey is found on every continent except Antarctica. It has white underparts and chocolate-brown upperparts, with a dark stripe through

the eye, and strongly curved talons and bill. It plucks live fish from the water during a spectacular, feet-first dive, sometimes totally submerging itself. Its feet have evolved to hold onto slippery prey, with spiny, dry scales on the undersides and a reversible outer toe for carrying fish head-first through the air.



Sagittarius serpentarius

Secretary bird



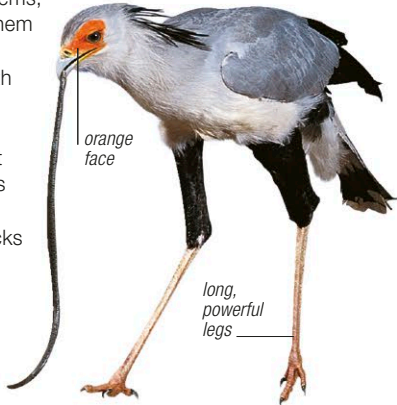
Length 4¼–5 ft (1.3–1.5 m)
Weight 5½–10 lb (2.5–4.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable

Location Africa (south of Sahara)



With its storklike legs, long, wedge-shaped tail, and crest of black feathers on the back of its head, the secretary bird is unlike any other raptor. The crest resembles a number of quill pens, as used in the past by secretaries. The flight feathers are black, and the rest of the body plumage is gray. The powerful legs are used for striking prey and running

after faster quarry. The secretary bird walks up to 15 miles (24 km) a day through grassland searching for prey. Food includes grasshoppers and other large insects, small mammals, frogs, snakes, lizards, and tortoises. The bird flushes out the prey by stamping on tufts of grass. It then runs after and catches moving items, dealing them repeated blows with its strong feet. The wings act as shields when the bird attacks snakes.



CONSERVATION

Through the California Condor Recovery Program, a captive-bred population of condors numbering just 27 in the 1980s has steadily grown to just over 400 birds today. About half of them are in captivity, and the remainder in the wild. The aim of the program is to re-establish a number of separate breeding colonies, which exist independently of human help, finding their own food.

